

Desk Lamp Story Problem Card Pack

Sixteen paper cards help writers shape fictional story problems with problem spots, character needs, place pressure, object trouble, questions, first tries, and revision prompts.

Audience: Families, co-op groups, tutors, and adult-led writing tables for writers ages 7-11.

Format: 16 printable problem cards plus adult guide tools, problem routines, take-home problem slips, and optional share prompts

Family-safe printable writing pages for adult-led, offline story practice.

\$55

Included

- 16 printable desk lamp problem cards
- Adult setup guide
- Fictional problem safety notes
- Desk lamp problem coaching moves
- Privacy and family handoff notes
- Pack reset notes
- Six adult-led problem routines
- Ten take-home problem slips
- Eight optional share prompts
- Provider-ready PDF and ZIP artifact

Problem coaching

Before the session

- Print the problem cards, blank slips, and adult guide before the adult-led paper session.
- Use a drawn desk lamp or pretend paper lamp as the shared story prop.
- Keep every prompt fictional, broad, offline, and printable from start to finish.
- Choose a small stack so each writer works with one gentle obstacle at a time.
- Remind writers that a first try can be changed when the problem becomes clearer.

Privacy and safety notes

- Use invented names, broad story labels, and pretend places only.
- Keep the activity paper-only, offline, and adult-led.
- Do not collect facts about actual writers, families, or daily life.
- If a detail sounds personal, replace it with a made-up lamp label or story object.
- Sharing stays optional and limited to one fictional word, sketch, or line.

Desk lamp problem setup

- Place the drawn desk lamp at the center of the paper set with four beam labels: clue, want, mismatch, first try.
- Let the adult read the card and point to the beam label that starts the problem.
- Ask writers to invent one made-up character, one missing clue, and one small story problem.
- Use blank slips for extra tries so crossed-out ideas can stay low-pressure.
- Keep the lamp idea broad: a glow, shade, pull cord, switch, base, or label can all become paper clues.

Family handoff

- Pass along one chosen paper slip and one blank slip for another fictional problem.
- Tell family adults to ask about the made-up obstacle, not actual life details.
- Invite praise for one clear clue, one first try, or one revised problem word.
- Keep the carry-along activity adult-led, offline, and paper-only.
- Ask family adults to leave narrow personal facts off the paper and keep the story invented.

Story problem coaching

- Ask what feels missing, mixed up, or not yet clear in the made-up story.
- Keep the obstacle small enough for one character choice and one first try.
- If the problem gets too large, shrink it to one clue under the lamp glow.
- Ask which detail changes after the first try so the next sentence has a purpose.
- Use gentle revision by swapping one vague word for a clearer invented clue.

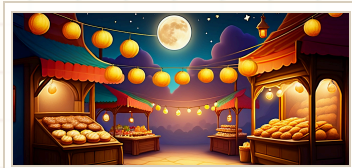
Reset

- Collect unused cards, blank slips, and the drawn desk lamp prop.
- Recycle scratch paper that includes narrow real-world facts.
- Save only fictional examples that can model gentle obstacles later.
- Restock the pack with fresh blank slips before the next paper session.

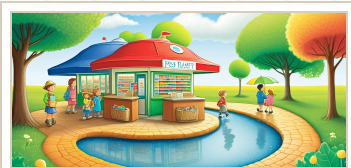
Use one desk lamp problem card at a time. Keep every choice broad, invented, and screen-free.

Sixteen problem-card worlds

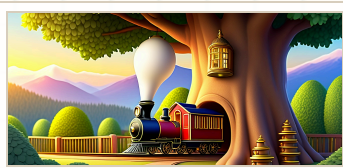
Pick a world image, then start one fictional story with a pretend desk lamp problem card.



AGES 6-8
Moon Muffin Market



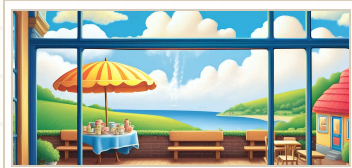
AGES 6-8
Puddle Planet Post Office



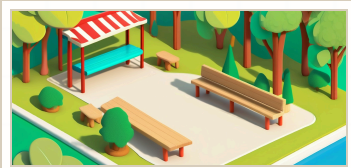
AGES 7-9
Buttonwood Library Train



AGES 7-9
Button Bakery Map Mix-Up



AGES 7-8
Teacup Town Weather Window



AGES 7-9
Pocket Park Notice Board



AGES 7-9
Spoon Ferry Lunchbox Harbor



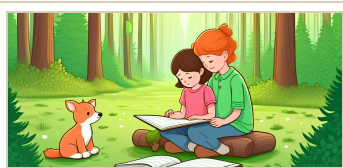
AGES 7-9
Acorn Avenue Errand Office



AGES 8-10
Seed Library Map Room



AGES 8-10
Rain Gauge Railway



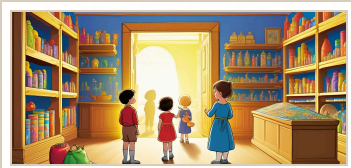
AGES 8-10
Moss Message Observatory



AGES 8-10
Tidepool Timekeepers Lab



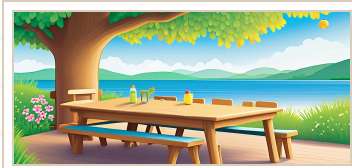
AGES 10-11
Revision River Ferry



AGES 10-11
Clue Label Tower Museum



AGES 10-11
Compass Craft Academy



AGES 10-11
Binding Day Boardwalk

Choose the desk lamp problem rhythm

Beam Label Pick Writers who need a simple way to name the small story problem. 1. The adult points to one lamp beam label: clue, want, mismatch, or first try. 2. The writer chooses one invented object under that beam. 3. The adult asks what small problem appears because the object is missing, mixed up, or unclear. 4. The writer writes one sentence that names the gentle obstacle.	Missing Clue Glow Writers who can start once one clue is absent or hidden. 1. The adult draws a glow circle on a blank slip. 2. The writer names the invented clue that should be inside the glow. 3. The adult asks why the character needs that clue before moving on. 4. The writer adds one first try that brings the clue closer.
Switch Mismatch Turning a mismatch into a clear fictional problem. 1. The adult sketches an on-off switch on paper. 2. The writer invents what changes when the switch moves. 3. The adult asks what no longer matches after the switch change. 4. The writer writes the mismatch as a small story problem.	Shade the Too-Big Problem Shrinking a large idea into one writable obstacle. 1. The adult draws a lamp shade over the largest part of the problem idea. 2. The writer chooses only one visible clue to keep. 3. The adult asks what the character can try first with that clue. 4. The writer rewrites the problem as one clear sentence.
Question Under the Lamp Writers who need the problem to become a question before drafting. 1. The adult places a blank question slip under the drawn desk lamp. 2. The writer names one character want and one missing clue. 3. The adult helps turn those two pieces into a gentle question. 4. The writer answers the question with a first try, not the final fix.	First Try, Better Try Showing that a problem can grow clearer after one attempt. 1. The adult reads the problem card and asks for one first try. 2. The writer writes the try even if it is not enough yet. 3. The adult asks what clue the try reveals. 4. The writer revises the problem using the new clue.

Start one story problem later

ONE PAPER PASS MISSING CLUE Glow Goes Missing Invent a desk lamp glow that points to one missing clue in a made-up story: _____. Ask which clue the character notices first: _____.	BRIEF ADULT-LED PASS MISMATCH Crooked Shade Clue Write a fictional problem where the lamp shade points one way but the clue points another way: _____. Ask what does not match yet: _____.
SINGLE PRINTABLE SLIP FIRST TRY Pull Cord First Try Create a made-up character who pulls a paper cord and makes one first try: _____. Ask what the first try helps the character learn: _____.	ONE PENCIL PASS STORY QUESTION Glow Label Trouble Invent a label under the desk lamp that raises a gentle problem question: _____. Ask which word on the label matters most: _____.
SHORT PAPER PASS OBJECT NEED Button Beacon Write a small story problem where a button beacon needs one invented object: _____. Ask what object would help without ending the story too fast: _____.	SINGLE CARD PASS CLUE ORDER Paper Beam Puzzle Draw or name three paper beams and choose the one that hides the first clue: _____. Ask why that beam comes first: _____.
CALM STORY PASS CAUSE AND FIX Tiny Switch Change Make the lamp switch change one pretend detail, then write the problem it causes: _____. Ask what gentle fix the character could try: _____.	QUIET PAPER PASS LABEL MISMATCH Base Label Mismatch Invent a lamp base label that does not match the story object beside it: _____. Ask what needs to be relabeled in the made-up story: _____.
FRESH SLIP PASS PROBLEM REVISION Soft Problem Shrink Take a too-large fictional problem and shrink it to one missing clue: _____. Ask which smaller version is easier to write next: _____.	SECOND PENCIL PASS REVISE THE PROBLEM Better Second Try Write a second try that makes the small story problem clearer than the first try: _____. Ask which word changed the problem most: _____.

- Optional share prompts
- Optional adult-led offline prompt: my small story problem is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: the missing clue under the lamp is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: the mismatch I invented is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: the character's first try is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: one lamp part that matters is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: the problem question I can read is _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: I made the problem clearer by changing _____.
 - Optional adult-led offline prompt: an adult can add one made-up clue here: _____.

Moon Muffin Lamp Crumb Mixup

Adult setup: Adult: Set this paper card beside a drawn desk lamp and invite one gentle moon-market obstacle: _____.

Look at the drawn lamp, then write the small problem the market helper notices: _____.



Moon Muffin Market

Problem spot
Problem spot: The tiny problem at the moon muffin stall is _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend market counter feels extra busy because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What needs to change so the muffin trade can keep going gently?
_____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the problem smaller and clearer by adding one missing moon-market clue:
_____.

Character need
Character need: The moon muffin helper needs _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp points to a crumb tag that _____.

First try
First try: The helper first tries to _____.

Quiet option: Draw the crumb tag first, then add one problem word: _____. **Take-home line:** Try another tiny pretend market problem on blank paper: _____.

Puddle Planet Missing Stamp

Adult setup: Adult: Set this printable card beside a drawn desk lamp and choose one puddle-mail clue to leave out: _____.

Find the missing clue before the puddle mail helper makes a first try: _____.



Puddle Planet Post Office

Problem spot
Problem spot: The small story problem appears when the puddle note has no _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend puddle counter cannot sort the note because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which clue is missing from the puddle note? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Add one clear missing clue so the problem is easier to notice:
_____.

Character need
Character need: The puddle mail helper needs a clue about _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp shines on a blank stamp spot that needs _____.

First try
First try: The helper first checks the paper edge for _____.

Quiet option: Circle the blank stamp spot and write one clue word: _____. **Take-home line:** Make another pretend mail note with one missing clue to fill in: _____.

Buttonwood Ticket Helper

Adult setup: Adult: Put the card beside blank paper and a drawn desk lamp, then name one pretend library-train need: _____.

Write what the traveler needs, then choose an action that actually helps: _____.



Buttonwood Library Train

Problem spot
Problem spot: The library-train problem begins when the ticket clue does not match _____.

Character need
Character need: The buttonwood traveler needs _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend shelf stop feels tangled because two book tickets point to _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp shows a ticket corner with _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What action best matches the traveler's need? _____.

First try
First try: The traveler first tries to _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Change the need or action so they fit together more clearly: _____.

Quiet option: Draw the ticket, then write one need and one action: _____. **Take-home line:** Try another pretend library-train problem by matching a need to an action: _____.

Button Bakery Crumb-Map Question

Adult setup: Adult: Set out the printable card, blank paper, and a drawn desk lamp beside a pretend crumb map: _____.

Before fixing anything, write the question the map-mender should ask: _____.



Button Bakery Map Mix-Up

Problem spot
Problem spot: The button bakery map problem shows up when _____.

Character need
Character need: The map-mender needs to understand _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend bakery counter feels mixed up because _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp points at a folded map corner that _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What question should the map-mender ask first? _____.

First try
First try: The map-mender first writes the question _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the question more exact by naming one crumb-map clue: _____.

Quiet option: Write only the question mark and one clue word first: _____. **Take-home line:** Use another pretend map problem and start with the clearest question: _____.

Teacup Weather Lamp Glow Mixup

Adult setup: Adult: Place this paper card beside a drawn desk lamp and choose two gentle weather clues that do not match: _____.

Look for the tiny mismatch, then write what seems different in Teacup Town: _____.



Teacup Town Weather Window

Problem spot
Problem spot: The tiny weather mismatch is _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend weather pane feels mixed up because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which weather clue does not match the scene? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Add one gentle weather detail that makes the mismatch easier to see: _____.

Character need
Character need: The teacup weather watcher needs to figure out _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp label says drizzle while the teacup cloud shows _____.

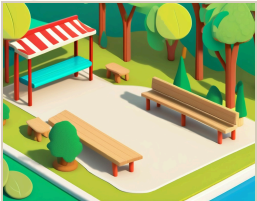
First try
First try: The watcher first compares _____.

Quiet option: Draw two weather symbols and mark the one that feels different: _____. Take-home line: Try another tiny pretend weather mismatch on blank paper: _____.

Pocket Park Notice First Try

Adult setup: Adult: Set the card beside blank paper and a drawn desk lamp, then offer one small pretend notice-board mixup: _____.

Name the small problem, then write the first try that makes the most sense: _____.



Pocket Park Notice Board

Problem spot Problem spot: The pocket-park notice problem is _____.	Character need Character need: The notice keeper needs _____.
Place pressure Place pressure: The pretend pocket-park board feels paused because _____.	Object trouble Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp points to a notice tack that _____.
Problem question Problem question: What is the first clear thing the notice keeper should try? _____.	First try First try: The notice keeper first tries to _____.
Revise problem Revise the problem: Make the first try clearer by adding one object clue: _____.	

Quiet option: Draw the notice tack, then write one first-try verb: _____. **Take-home line:** Make another pretend notice-board problem and choose one clear first try: _____.

Spoon Ferry Cracker Dock Problem

Adult setup: Adult: Print this card and set a drawn desk lamp idea beside it; invite one invented harbor detail only: _____.

Write a gentle obstacle that starts when the spoon ferry reaches the harbor edge: _____.



Spoon Ferry Lunchbox Harbor

Problem spot
Problem spot: The first small story problem appears when the spoon ferry reaches _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The cracker dock, napkin tide, or lunchbox lid makes the crossing harder because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What gentle obstacle should the ferry solve before the story can continue? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the setting pressure clearer by adding one sight, sound, or texture: _____.

Character need
Character need: The tiny ferryperson needs help carrying, finding, or choosing _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp glow shows one story object out of place, such as _____.

First try
First try: The helper first tries to balance, fold, or nudge _____.

Quiet option: Point to the dock detail and write one small problem word: _____. **Take-home line:** On paper, invent one more spoon ferry problem using a drawn desk lamp clue: _____.

Acorn Avenue Errand Slip Tangle

Adult setup: Adult: Print this card and ask for made-up errand slips, pretend stamps, and invented tasks only: _____.

Write a small story problem where two pretend tasks get matched the wrong way: _____.



Acorn Avenue Errand Office

Problem spot
Problem spot: At Acorn Avenue, two pretend errand slips get mixed because _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The acorn counter is crowded with twig trays, making the mix-up harder because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which task belongs to which character, and what clue proves it? _____

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the task mix-up clearer by changing one clue on a slip: _____

Character need
Character need: The leaf clerk needs the helper to match the right task to _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp glow lands on the wrong stamp, label, or seed tag: _____

First try
First try: The helper sorts one slip by shape, color, or tiny symbol: _____

Quiet option: Draw two errand slips and mark the one that seems mismatched: _____. **Take-home line:** Use paper to invent another acorn errand mix-up with no real chores: _____.

Seed Library Map Shelf Mismatch

Adult setup: Adult: Print this card and invite a drawn desk lamp idea to shine on one invented map shelf clue: _____.

Write a small story problem where a seed map mark does not match the shelf clue: _____.



Seed Library Map Room

Problem spot
Problem spot: The seed map on the table shows one path beside the shelf, but the seed tag says _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The map table is full of folded charts, so the mismatch matters because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which map clue should the character trust first, and why? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Replace any confusing map clue with a clearer fictional symbol: _____.

Character need
Character need: The map keeper needs the writer to decide which symbol belongs with _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp glow reveals a seed pin, paper compass, or shelf card that does not match _____.

First try
First try: The helper compares one symbol, one border, and one seed tag: _____.

Quiet option: Sketch one map symbol and write what it is supposed to mean: _____. **Take-home line:** Invent another seed library map mismatch on paper using a desk lamp clue: _____.

Rain Gauge Railway Signal Tangle

Adult setup: Adult: Print this card and place a drawn desk lamp idea near the page; all railway signals stay fictional: _____.

Write a small story problem where two railway signals do not agree: _____.



Rain Gauge Railway

Problem spot
Problem spot: The rain gauge points to silver drizzle while the signal flag shows _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The puddle platform, gauge stand, or paper bridge makes the signal mismatch matter because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which signal should the character test first on the story page?

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the signal mismatch clearer by changing one pretend mark:

Character need
Character need: The rain-note conductor needs help choosing what the mixed signals mean for _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp glow reveals a wet ticket, glass tube, or cloud note with the wrong mark: _____.

First try
First try: The helper compares the gauge mark with one flag, bell, or cloud note:

Quiet option: Draw two signals and circle the one that does not fit: _____. **Take-home line:** On paper, invent another rain gauge signal mismatch with a desk lamp clue: _____.

Moss Observatory Missing Middle Note

Adult setup: Adult: Print this card and ask for a pretend moss note with one gentle missing clue: _____.

Write a small story problem where a moss message leaves out one important word: _____.



Moss Message Observatory

Problem spot
Problem spot: The moss note has a gentle gap where the key word should be _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The lantern shelf, moss step, or pebble-lens table makes the gap important because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What does the message need to say so the character can make a first try? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the message gap clearer by adding one soft clue before the blank: _____.

Character need
Character need: The sky watcher needs help filling one missing message clue for _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk lamp glow falls on a folded sky chart with one blank space: _____.

First try
First try: The observer checks one moss mark, one pebble lens, and one chart edge: _____.

Quiet option: Copy the moss note and leave one gentle blank to fill: _____. **Take-home line:** Invent another moss message gap on paper using a desk lamp clue: _____.

Tidepool Clock Pebble Order Mix

Adult setup: Adult: Set this paper card beside a drawn desk-lamp idea and invite an invented tidepool order mismatch: _____.

Spot which tidepool timekeeper clue comes before or after another clue, then write the small story problem: _____.



Tidepool Timekeepers Lab

Problem spot
Problem spot: Three shell-clock notes are out of order, and the confusing clue is _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend tidepool lab has one changing mark that makes the order matter: _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which clue should come first, next, and last in this make-believe lab? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the mixed-up order smaller, clearer, and easier to follow by _____.

Character need
Character need: The tidepool timekeeper needs the next correct note so they can _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk-lamp idea shines on a shell tag, bead dial, or paper tide strip that does not fit because _____.

First try
First try: The timekeeper gently tests the sequence by _____.

Quiet option: Number three pretend clues on paper and fill one blank: _____. **Carry-on line:** On another paper slip, invent one new order mismatch for the tidepool lab: _____.

Revision River Lantern Target

Adult setup: Adult: Place the printable card near a drawn desk-lamp idea and ask which ferry detail needs clearer wording: _____.

Choose one fuzzy ferry problem, mark what needs to change, and write the revision target on paper: _____.



Revision River Ferry

Problem spot
Problem spot: The ferry helper cannot tell which sentence, clue, or action needs clearer wording because _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend ferry crossing feels misty, crowded with clues, or unclear because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What exact story part should be revised first? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Turn the broad ferry trouble into one clear revision target by _____.

Character need
Character need: The revision river helper needs a clear target so the story can _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk-lamp idea points to a lantern tag, rope note, or ferry card that needs revision because _____.

First try
First try: The ferry helper gently underlines one target and tries to _____.

Quiet option: Circle one fuzzy ferry word and write its clearer replacement: _____. **Carry-on line:** On a later paper slip, choose one pretend ferry detail to revise: _____.

Clue Label Tower Tag Mix-Up

Adult setup: Adult: Set out the paper card and a drawn desk-lamp idea, then invite one invented exhibit label mismatch: _____.

Find the label that points to the wrong clue, then write the small story problem it creates: _____.



Clue Label Tower Museum

Problem spot
Problem spot: One tower label names the wrong clue, and the mix-up begins when _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend tower museum has many tags, shelves, or display cards, so the label must _____.

Problem question
Problem question: Which label clue tells the reader where to look next? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the label clue more specific by adding one shape, color, or display detail: _____.

Character need
Character need: The clue keeper needs the label to help them notice _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk-lamp idea shines on a label stand, paper magnifier, or display tag that causes trouble by _____.

First try
First try: The clue keeper gently swaps, points, or rewrites one label to _____.

Quiet option: Draw one label box and fill only the clue word: _____. **Carry-on line:** Invent one new paper label that points to a pretend tower clue: _____.

PROBLEM CARD 15 | AGES 10-11 | CHOICE OBSTACLE

Compass Craft Forked Arrow Choice

Adult setup: Adult: Place this printable card beside a drawn desk-lamp idea and offer two invented compass choices on paper: _____.

Write the moment the compass crafter must choose between two paper arrows, beads, or marks: _____.



Compass Craft Academy

Problem spot Problem spot: Two compass craft choices both seem useful, and the obstacle is _____.	Character need Character need: The compass crafter needs to choose one option so they can _____.
Place pressure Place pressure: The pretend craft academy has a bead rail, needle hall, or folded arrow gate that makes the choice matter because _____.	Object trouble Object trouble: The drawn desk-lamp idea reveals a paper needle, craft tag, or bead card that points two ways because _____.
Problem question Problem question: Which choice helps the character move the story forward, and why? _____.	First try First try: The compass crafter gently tests one choice by _____.
Revise problem Revise the problem: Make the choice obstacle clearer by naming the two options and one tradeoff: _____.	

Quiet option: Mark option A or option B, then write one reason: _____.

Carry-on line: Sketch two pretend compass choices on paper and choose one: _____.

Binding Day Promise Knot

Adult setup: Adult: Set this card beside a drawn desk-lamp idea and invite one invented promise that can be kept kindly: _____.

Write the small problem that appears when a boardwalk page helper tries to keep a promise: _____.



Binding Day Boardwalk

Problem spot
Problem spot: The promise becomes tricky when a page, sign, or clasp is different from what the helper expected: _____.

Place pressure
Place pressure: The pretend binding boardwalk has page signs, thread loops, or booth notes that make the promise matter because _____.

Problem question
Problem question: What kind choice lets the helper keep the promise without making the story too big? _____.

Revise problem
Revise the problem: Make the promise problem smaller, kinder, and easier to solve by _____.

Character need
Character need: The page helper needs to keep the promise by _____.

Object trouble
Object trouble: The drawn desk-lamp idea shines on a thread loop, page clasp, or folded sign that complicates the promise by _____.

First try
First try: The page helper gently tries to keep the promise by _____.

Quiet option: Draw the promised object and write one helpful action: _____. Carry-on line: On another paper slip, invent one small promise a boardwalk helper can keep: _____.